sants (saints), both male and female, who took Ramananda's teachings to the masses.

Bhakti had its stars—poet-saints like Kabir (c. 1440–1510 CE), who wrote some extraordinarily compelling verses distilling the essence of Hindu philosophy, and who was singing in praise of religious harmony at a time when the West was conducting Inquisitions and burning witches and heretics at the stake; Lalleshwari or Lalla Rukh (c. 1317–1372 CE), the great Bhakti songstress of Kashmir, who sang passionately of her devotion to Shiva but as emotionally of her refusal to discriminate between Hindu and Muslim; mystic singers like Mirabai (c. 1498–1597 CE), whose songs transported the singer and her audience into a level of ecstasy reminiscent of some of today's Evangelical churches; the twelfth-century poet Jayadev, whose *Gita Govindam* revolutionised the worship of Radha and Krishna, and whose ideas were echoed in the lyrics of the blind bard Surdas (c. 1478–1583 CE), the man who helped establish the Vrindavan-Mathura area as Krishna's holy land; and the remarkable writer, poet and saint Tulsidas (c. 1532–1623 CE), author of two of the most popular Hindu texts even today, the *Ramcharitmanas*, retelling the story of Lord Rama, and the Hanuman Chalisa, forty-three devotional verses in praise of the powerful monkey-god. Tulsidas wrote in Avadhi (though initially in Sanskrit); Kabir's verse can still be understood by Hindi speakers today. Verse and song became vehicles for Bhakti ideas throughout India.

Mirabai's husband, the Rana of Udaipur, allegedly disapproved so much of her devotion to Lord Krishna that he tried to poison her, but miraculously the poison turned into honey as she drank it, and she danced in ecstasy before her adored Lord. As one of her hymns declares with the sense of abandonment and ecstatic devotion for which she is known:

Tying anklets upon her feet, Mira dances in ecstasy.
People say Mira has gone mad.
Her mother-in-law says she has disgraced the clan,
The Rana sent her a cup of poison,
Which Mira, laughingly, drank.
I have myself become the eternal maid-servant of
My Narayana.
Mira's God is Giridhar, lifter of the mountain.